

Sweetwater Center for the Arts

Executive Summary

Client

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Student Consulting Team

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Background

Sweetwater Center for the Arts is a nonprofit community arts organization founded in 1974, serving communities west of Pittsburgh. Its mission is to provide transformative artistic experiences through classes, exhibitions, and outreach programs that support both artists and the broader community.

The Sweetwater Artist Member Initiative (SAMI) is a new membership program designed to support regional artists at all career stages. The program provides access to professional development resources, community connections, and opportunities for artistic growth. As a new initiative, SAMI required a clear and accessible digital presence to support its launch and long-term success.

Project Description

Project Opportunity

At the start of the project, Sweetwater lacked a dedicated digital platform for SAMI. There was no centralized location where users could learn about the program, understand membership benefits, or navigate the application process. Artist visibility was also limited to temporary exhibitions and events, with no persistent online presence.

The opportunity was to create a unified platform that could support program promotion, artist showcasing, and member engagement while integrating with existing systems and remaining manageable for staff.

Project Vision

The final solution was the development of the SAMI Platform, a standalone website built using a custom WordPress theme. The platform serves as a centralized digital hub for the program, supporting both public and member-facing functionality.

The platform includes structured informational pages, application pathways integrated with SlideRoom and Sawyer, and a “Meet Our Artists” section with dedicated artist profile pages. It also includes login functionality and protected pages for member-only content, enabling Sweetwater to support ongoing engagement beyond the application process.

Project Outcomes

From a technology perspective, the project delivered a custom WordPress website with core features including a homepage, applications page, artist profiles, calendar, partners page, and login system. These features provide a complete and accessible digital experience.

From a process perspective, the platform introduced a structured workflow for program interaction. Users can now discover SAMI, navigate applications, and access content through a centralized system. This reduces reliance on manual communication and creates a scalable process for managing membership growth. Artist promotion also shifted from temporary exposure to a persistent online system.

From a people perspective, the platform delivers value to multiple stakeholders. Staff can manage content directly and reduce repetitive communication. Artists benefit from increased visibility through professional profile pages. Community members gain easier access to information and a structured way to discover artists.

The platform also establishes a foundation for long-term engagement through member login functionality and protected resources, though some advanced workflows require further configuration.

Project Deliverables

The final deliverables include a fully functional SAMI Platform built as a custom WordPress theme, along with integration into Sweetwater's existing systems. The team also provided documentation and guidance to support future maintenance, updates, and completion of remaining configurations.

Recommendations

To further strengthen the platform, Sweetwater should complete the application-to-login workflow using Gravity Forms to streamline member onboarding. The organization should also continue populating artist profiles and managing member content to maintain engagement.

Over time, expanding features such as member resources and community tools will further increase the platform's value and support long-term program growth.

Student Consulting Team

- **Ted Gershon** served as Project Manager and Client Relations Lead. He is a third-year Information Systems major with a minor in Business Administration and is interested in communication design.
- **James Lee** served as Development Lead. He is a senior studying Information Systems with a minor in Machine Learning and will be working at Amazon as a Machine Learning Engineer this summer. He led website development, debugging, and staging.
- **Stephanie Reed** served as UI/UX Design Lead. She is a third-year Information Systems major with an additional major in Human-Computer Interaction. She is focused on user experience design and led interface design and usability testing.
- **Sunny Guo** served as a UI/UX Designer. She is a third-year BXA major studying Information Systems and Art. She supported design and usability testing throughout the project.